Tawang salient where Tibetan dzongpens (local governors) and their henchmen were still exercising control.

Major Bob Khathing, the assistant political officer in Pasighat, was summoned by the governor to Shillong and ordered to take a column of Assam Rifles up to Tawang to establish an administration there. A former Assam Rifles officer, Khathing, with an escort of three platoons from 5 Assam Rifles under the command of Captain H. B. Limbu, reached Dirang Dzong on 1 February 1951. The column then crossed Se-la with considerable difficulty and succeeded in establishing an Assam Rifles checkpost at Jang. Khathing finally reached Tawang, where a representative of the Tsona Dzong dzongpen received him. The local Monpas, in light of the subsequent vengeance let loose on them by the dzongpens for having supported the Lightfoot Expedition in 1938, stayed away from the Indian officials.

Three days later the dzongpen met with Khathing who formally announced that from ‘the third day of the Iron-Haired Year, corresponding with 9 February 1951 the administration of Tawang and its monastery would be the responsibility of the Government of India’, and that the Tsona dzongpen or any other official of the Tibetan government could no longer exercise authority over the villages south of Bum-la that lay on the McMahon Line. The dzongpen were to cease collection of taxes and any tributes forthwith.

The dzongpen immediately referred the matter to Lhasa, while informing the Indians that they had no idea the area had been ceded to India in 1914. In no mood to wait for Lhasa’s reply, Khathing started establishing his own administration by setting up the Assam Rifles post and touring most Monpa villages. He issued orders to the various village chiefs, started building bashas (temporary shelters) and also visited the lamas in the Tawang Monastery. Amusingly, Khathing had to levy an annual house tax of Rs 5 on each Monpa dwelling, for only then were the Monpas convinced that the Indians meant business and that they were, after all, citizens of India.

Though it will remain in the realm of speculation, it is quite likely that the Bob Khathing column into Tawang was Sardar Patel’s last gift to the nation. An Intelligence operative who later worked for the IB from Tawang claimed the expedition was the brainchild of Mullik and had the blessing of the home minister who had instructed the Assam governor to bring Tawang